A MAMMOTH MISSION

Richie Mehta has created an in-depth series on man-animal conflict in Amazon Prime Video's *Poacher*

"Beautiful mess." That's how actor Nimisha Sajayan describes her character, a forest department official who's #TeamElephant, in the latest Amazon Prime Video series *Poacher*. Created by Richie Mehta of *Delhi Crime* fame, the label also applies to Mehta's work. The London-based writer-director shows the mess in society "through the eyes of people cleaning it up", he notes. Inspired by true events in Kerala, the multilingual dramatic thriller centres on the unsung heroes who rally together to track the network that kills elephants to keep the illegal ivory trade going. While Nimisha's character Mala has an animal activist's zeal to capture the culprits, *Poacher* also touches upon the man-animal conflict in the state. Says Mehta, "One thing about animals that is interesting is they don't take more than they require, as opposed to us." The show also touches on the 'animalistic' side of humans through the crimes they commit on the voiceless creatures. Mehta, fresh from the International Emmy Award win for *Delhi Crime*, wanted to use the "little bit of leverage" he had amassed in the film industry to do "something noble". *Poacher* took him to Malayattoor and other parts of Kerala and places like Dehradun, as he interviewed forest department officials as well as former poachers as research for the show. "My view of the ecosystem [thus far] was the urban environment, but here is another world and we haven't destroyed it yet," says Mehta about the journey, which at one point would entail seeing the majestic creatures in the wild.

Poacher, like *Delhi Crime*, is an acquisition and not a commissioned project. It implies that Mehta finds international producers who believe in his vision and his ability to execute it, freeing him from the creative diktats of streaming platforms. Mehta's work process involves shuttling between London and India. "It is necessary that I don't reside in an industry town because it is easy to get caught up in the business of moviemaking," he says. "Most of my time is [spent] on creation of content and dissemination of research and, most important, [answering] 'why' this project." *Poacher* adds to the conversation around coexistence, preservation and conservation. Sajayan, an acclaimed actor in Malayalam cinema, says it will "be an eye-opener" for people in Kerala. "I want audiences to feel how our actions reflect on the animal kingdom," she says. Mehta hopes audiences watch the entirety of the eight episodes and especially "the last scene" to understand why he devoted nearly four years to the project. It remains to be seen where the audience's loyalty lies by the end of it, but they will certainly root for the silent guardians of the forest. ■

–Suhani Singh

The dramatic thriller centres on **UNSUNG HEROES** who band together to track elephant poachers

